The Pre-Production Marketing Playbook

Nov 11, 2026 · SMACC Fall 2026 research

Draft white paper, SMACC Fall 2026. Six films show that a hit's marketing hook is decided before cameras roll: blockbusters win by turning release into an event, and small-budget films win by turning their audience into the marketing department.

Executive summary

All six films in this study were hits, but they reached audiences in two different ways, and both were set up before filming began. Five findings carry the playbook:

1. **The hook is decided in pre-production.** The Odyssey's IMAX film cameras, Sinners' two 65mm formats, Obsession's YouTube-creator director and Backrooms' existing online world were all locked in before any marketing began. Each became the campaign.
2. **Blockbusters sell an event.** First trailers came 206–380 days before release, reported marketing ran 50–103% of the production budget, and premium screens took up to 53% of an opening. Each returned $2.55–$4.91 in worldwide ticket sales for every $1 spent making and marketing it.
3. **Small-budget films sell participation.** Made for $750K–$25M, they earned 8.8 to 695 times their budgets. Fan-made content did the reach: 602M views of the "Unwritten" exit dance, 400,000 people texting Obsession's Nikki and 1.1B Backrooms TikTok views.
4. **Trust drives attendance more than hype.** The top reasons people came were a name they trusted (51% came for Christopher Nolan; 58% came for the Backrooms story) and friends (45% of Sinners viewers cited word of mouth). Skipping influencer screenings did not hurt The Odyssey's early reviews.
5. **A big opening is not a long run.** Films earned 2.4 to 15.3 times their opening weekend over their US runs. The two smallest openings had the longest runs; the biggest fan-driven opening had the shortest.

Research question and method

We asked one question: what should a studio lock in before cameras roll to give a film the best chance of becoming a hit? To answer it at two scales, we compared three studio blockbusters (The Odyssey, Barbie, Sinners) with three small-budget releases

(Obsession, Anyone But You, Backrooms), all released between 2023 and 2026.

The data comes from seven team workbooks built over the semester:

Workbook	What it covers
Six-Film Master Data	Box office, budgets, marketing spend, release dates, review scores and campaign tactics for all six films, with a logged source for each value
Gen Z Master Data	Audience age and gender, exit-poll reasons for attending, and X, TikTok and Reddit samples pulled with the Xpoz social tool
Cast Data	2,406 social posts about The Odyssey's cast, plus star, pairing and fan-participation measures for all six
Technical Craft (three workbooks)	Formats, shoot facts, premium-screen shares, a profit model and 646 hand-coded Reddit and Letterboxd posts
Odyssey Sentiment and Trust	1,137 Letterboxd, Reddit and Metacritic entries testing whether skipping influencer screenings hurt early sentiment

Every film was scored on the same eight questions, with 25 data points in all: did it work, how was it received, what was made, who was in it and who they reached, how it was sold, who showed up, what people said online, and did it last. Where workbooks disagreed, box office, budgets and scores follow the Six-Film Master Data; each specialist workbook is used for its own topic. Values the team could not confirm with a second source are marked unverified.

The six films at a glance

The blockbusters cost 3.6 to 333 times more to make than the small-budget films, but all six earned well past the usual breakeven of about 2.5 times the production budget.

Film	Tier	Studio	US release	Budget ($M)	Reported marketing ($M)	US opening ($M)	US total ($M)	Worldwide ($M)
The Odyssey	Blockbuster	Universal	Jul 17, 2026	250	125 (unverified)	123.5	625.6	1,820.9
Barbie	Blockbuster	Warner Bros.	Jul 21, 2023	145	150	162.0	636.8	1,447.7
Sinners	Blockbuster	Warner Bros.	Apr 18, 2025	90	55	48.0	280.0	370.3
Obsession	Small budget	Focus Features	May 15, 2026	0.75	Not reported	17.2	263.5	521.3
Anyone But You	Small budget	Sony	Dec 22, 2023	25	65	6.0	88.3	219.8
Backrooms	Small budget	A24	May 29, 2026	10	10 (unverified)	81.4	197.5	400.1

US figures cover the US and Canada. Totals are as of each film's latest data date in the Six-Film Master (The Odyssey: Oct 29, 2026).

Finding 1: Did it work?

Every film beat the forecasts that existed for it, but the small films earned far more per dollar. Backrooms returned $20 for every $1 of production and marketing cost; the blockbusters returned $2.55 to $4.91.

Film	Opening vs. forecast	Forecast used	Worldwide per $1 of total cost	Worldwide ÷ budget	Estimated profit ($M)
Backrooms	4.1×	$20M early tracking (final week: $40M–$55M)	$20.00	40.0×	237
Barbie	2.2×	Warner's own $75M	$4.91	10.0×	548
The Odyssey	1.4×	$80M–$100M	$4.86	7.3×	788
Obsession	1.7×	About $10M	Not reported	695×	311
Sinners	1.4×	Mid-$30Ms	$2.55	4.1×	83
Anyone But You	No forecast published	—	$2.44	8.8×	60

Total cost is production budget plus reported marketing. Estimated profit comes from the craft workbook's model of studio revenue and costs; where trades reported a figure, it lands close for Barbie (Deadline: about $500M) and below for Anyone But You (Deadline: $103M, helped by its Netflix deal).

Trackers underestimated every film that had a forecast, most of all the fan-driven ones. Backrooms opened at about four times early tracking, and Barbie at more than twice Warner's own projection.

Finding 2: How was it received?

Strong reviews were common but not required: Anyone But You succeeded with 53% from critics because 87% of audiences liked it. The widest split ran the other way, with critics rating The Odyssey 31 points higher than everyday Metacritic users.

Film	RT critics	Critic reviews (RT + Metacritic)	Metascore	Metacritic users (out of 100)	RT audience	CinemaScore
Sinners	97%	438 + 55	84	75	96%	A
The Odyssey	94%	214 + 63	88	57	97%	A
Obsession	93%	330 + 38	77	78	94%	A-
Barbie	88%	509 + 67	80	58	83%	A
Backrooms	85%	319 + 47	76	71	74%	B-

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Anyone But You	53%	118 + 26	52	58	87%	B+

The Odyssey's low Metacritic user score is a Metacritic story, not a general loss of trust: its Rotten Tomatoes audience score was 97% and its CinemaScore an A. The Odyssey Sentiment and Trust study found its earliest Letterboxd fans averaged 4.61 stars (89% positive), close to Barbie (4.55, 97%) and above Oppenheimer (4.16, 84%), and that hype or trust complaints appeared in only 0–3% of early posts.

The CinemaScore grade tracked staying power better than critics did: the three A-grade blockbusters ran 3.9–5.8 times their openings, while B- Backrooms ran 2.4 times.

Finding 3: What was made

How a film was made became its marketing. Big films sold scarcity, a format you could only see in a few theaters; small films sold constraint, a story about doing a lot with very little.

Film	Signature production choice	Why it mattered and who it reached	Audience posts about the filmmaking
Backrooms	30,000+ sq ft of real sets built from the director's own 3D designs	Rebuilt the yellow rooms fans knew from YouTube; 58% came for the Backrooms story	28%
Sinners	Two 65mm formats in one film; Oscar-winning score and cinematography	Sent fans to premium screens (45% of opening); reached awards voters with a record 16 Oscar nominations	25%
The Odyssey	First film shot entirely on IMAX film: 91 shoot days in 6 countries	Premium screens earned 53% of the opening and IMAX $555M worldwide; drew film lovers and Gen Z	24%

Film	Signature production choice	Why it mattered and who it reached	Audience posts about the filmmaking
Barbie	Hand-built, hand-painted pink Barbie Land	The pink-paint shortage made news 46 days before release; drew the most female audience (65%)	14%
Anyone But You	Real Sydney locations; "Unwritten" as a recurring song cue	Gave winter audiences an escape and gave fans a scene to recreate	12%
Obsession	$750K, 20 shoot days, one prop and one look	The underdog story sold it to Focus for about $15M, 20 times its budget; the prop and makeup became TikTok trends	9%

Filmmaking talk did not create staying power. Backrooms had the most craft talk and the shortest run (2.4 times its opening), while Obsession and Anyone But You had the least and ran about 15 times theirs. Craft opens the door; story and word of mouth keep people coming. Craft-talk shares come from small hand-coded samples (94–116 posts per film), so gaps under about 5 points are noise.

Finding 4: Who was in it and who they reached

The less famous the cast, the more the fans did the marketing. Famous casts created events, such as premieres and press tours, while unknown or rising casts handed fans something to copy.

Film	Cast strategy	Cast share of X posts (cast vs. director)	Cast reach	Fan participation
Anyone But You	Rising stars	94% (35 posts; thin archive)	Sweeney's TikTok following up 129%, Powell's 76%	602M views of the "Unwritten" exit dance

Film	Cast strategy	Cast share of X posts (cast vs. director)	Cast reach	Fan participation
Barbie	Star-producer	66% (735 posts; thin archive)	Robbie and Gosling named about twice as often as Gerwig	200,000+ same-day Barbenheimer double features
Obsession	Unknown lead	53%	Cast posts rose from 146 to 1,254 after release	400,000 people texting Nikki; 6.4M views on one makeup recreation
The Odyssey	All-star ensemble	36%	44% came for the cast; Zendaya and Holland videos reached about 3.4 times more people	33% of TikTok views from fans with under 10,000 followers
Sinners	Star + director	26%	47% came for Michael B. Jordan	Gold-grillz look copied from the premiere
Backrooms	Creator-led	9%	Director named almost 10 times as often as the cast	1.1B views from about 10,000 fan TikToks

Stars work best in pairs. On The Odyssey's TikTok, videos with two or more stars drew 5.4 times the median views of single-star videos, and one star alone did no better than none. For Anyone But You, a casual Sweeney–Powell whisper clip (18M views) beat the official trailer (10M) by 1.8 times. Pairing was only measured for these two films.

Star power opened films but did not hold them. The famous-cast films fell 27–43% in their second weekends, while the rising and unknown casts grew (+46% and +39%).

Finding 5: How it was sold

Blockbusters bought time and premium screens; small films ran short campaigns on top of an audience that already existed. The Odyssey sold IMAX 70mm tickets a full year out, while Obsession opened presales just 16 days before release.

Film	First trailer (days before release)	Tickets on sale (days before)	First reactions	Rollout approach	Definite recommend (exit poll)	Premium-screen share of opening
The Odyssey	380	365	11 days out, at the London premiere	Theaters-only teaser; influencer screenings withheld	81%	53%
Barbie	217	30	11 days out	Influencer-first; 244 influencer partnerships	Not published (5 of 5 PostTrak stars)	10% (unverified)
Sinners	206	23 (unverified)	Reviews lifted 8 days out	Celebrity IMAX screening; sports TV spots	84%	45%
Anyone But You	242 (unverified)	36 (unverified)	11 days out	Influencer Get Ready with Me videos	57%	Not reported
Obsession	164	16	Toronto festival, 8 months out	Creator and fan screenings; interactive billboards	70%	0%
Backrooms	94	59	Premiere 22 days out	In-universe ads and lore clues	53%	17%

Scarcity built buzz. The Odyssey's first teaser ran only in theaters, and about 95% of its IMAX 70mm seats sold within an hour of going on sale. Its London and Paris premiere day drew 51 times a normal day of posts.

Withholding influencer screenings did not cost trust. The Odyssey's early fan reviews were as positive as influencer-first Barbie's, and Barbie scored about the same with everyday Metacritic users (5.8 vs. 5.7). The rollout choice did not explain audience trust; the films themselves did.

Premium screens are a blockbuster lever. The Odyssey (53%) and Sinners (45%) took about half their openings from IMAX and premium screens, helped by Ryan Coogler's own video explaining the formats. None of the small films played IMAX.

Finding 6: Who showed up

As budgets fell, audiences got younger: 78–88% of the small-budget creator films' opening crowds were under 35, against 55–81% for the blockbusters. People came for a name they trusted, and they came together.

Film	Top reasons to attend (exit polls)	Gender	Age	Opening per-theater average
Barbie	Not asked; about 3 tickets per purchase	65% female	81% under 35; 40% under 25	$38,186
The Odyssey	Nolan 51%, cast 44%	59% male	55% under 35	$31,514
Backrooms	Backrooms story 58%, A24 50%+, director 30%	62% male	88% under 35; average age 25	$23,665
Sinners	Michael B. Jordan 47%, word of mouth 45%, Coogler 40%	57% male	64% under 35; 20% under 25	$14,513
Obsession	Not asked	59% male	78% under 35	$6,576
Anyone But You	Not asked	Mostly women	No opening split; 37% aged 18–24 by weekend three	$1,964

The Gen Z research groups the drivers into three: **together** (87% of Gen Z saw a film in theaters in the past year, more than any other generation, and cite going with friends as the top reason), **trusted** (a name or community they already follow) and **can't-miss** (an event, such as an IMAX 70mm screening).

Casts shaped who came. A young, fan-favorite ensemble helped a three-hour epic draw about half its audience aged 18–34, and Margot Robbie's fashion-led campaign pulled the most female audience of the six. Word of mouth widened Sinners' audience: under-25 viewers rose from 20% at opening to 34% in weekend two. Demographic brackets differ by tracker (18–34, under 25, under 35), and no film published a full-run age split.

Finding 7: What people said online

Creator films won TikTok reach; The Odyssey won sustained conversation. In samples of each film's 100 latest TikToks, Obsession (14.5M plays) and Backrooms (13.6M) drew about three times The Odyssey's 4.4M, while The Odyssey led X posts over the last 90 days (2,159).

Film	X posts around release	Letterboxd average (share rating 4.5–5 stars)	Headline reach	Fan-made content (UGC)
The Odyssey	21,156	4.3 (60%)	121.4M first-trailer views in 24 hours	37 of 52 sampled creator videos unpaid
Backrooms	22,079	3.3 (13%)	17 sampled TikToks over 100,000 plays, the most of the six	About 10,000 fan TikToks in the release month
Obsession	2,332	4.1 (44%)	8.1M plays on its top TikTok	652,000+ #Obsession TikTok posts
Sinners	2,275	4.1 (48%)	77.1M TikTok views (unverified)	10.5M fan creations in four months (unverified)
Barbie	Archive too thin	3.7 (28%)	4.6B #BarbieTheMovie views (company-reported)	13M Barbie Selfie Generator users
Anyone But You	Archive too thin	2.8 (10%)	2.7B #AnyoneButYou TikTok views (company-reported)	265,000 #Unwritten TikTok videos

The Odyssey's first trailer spread across platforms: TikTok 27% of views, YouTube 26%, Facebook 21%, Instagram 18% and X 10%. None of the workbooks has audience demographics broken out by platform.

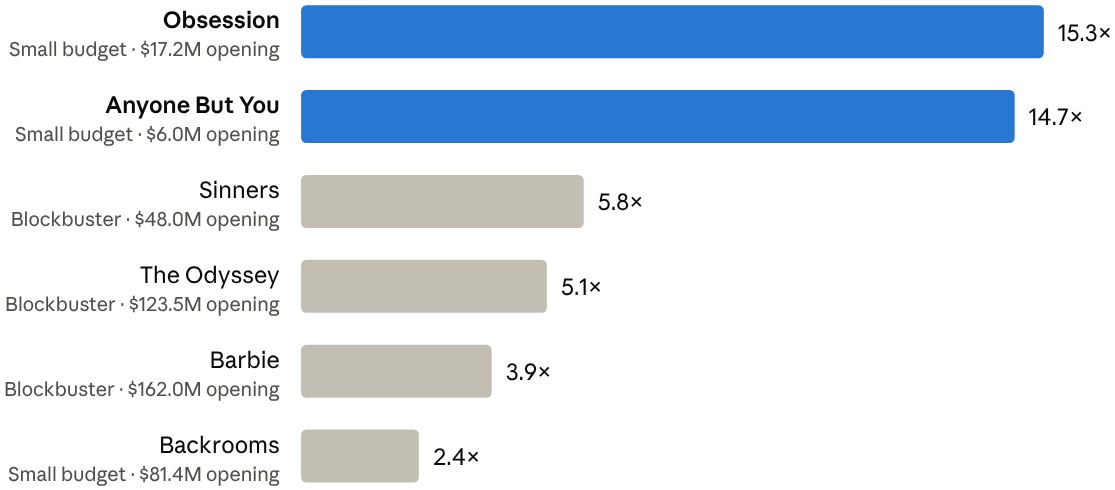
Two viral patterns appear. Backrooms had a deep bench of fans constantly posting, while Obsession's reach came from a few mega-hits, the signature of a word-of-mouth sleeper. Audiences talked about characters and meaning (Ken, Nikki, the Backrooms lore) more than about the campaigns' own taglines.

Finding 8: Did it last?

A built-in audience guarantees the opening, not the run. Obsession and Anyone But You grew in their second weekends (up 39% and 46%) as word of mouth spread, while Backrooms' fans packed its opening and it fell 68% the next weekend.

The two smallest openings had the longest runs

US total gross as a multiple of the opening weekend



Six-Film Master Data · US totals as of each film's latest data date

Among the blockbusters, Sinners held best (down 5% in weekend two) on an A CinemaScore and strong word of mouth; Barbie was the most front-loaded. Late format events also extended runs: The Odyssey rose 65% when IMAX screens returned in week 13.

The blockbuster playbook ($90M–$250M)

At this scale the opening weekend is the bet, so the campaign has to turn the release into an event, then earn the second weekend.

1. **Lock a big-screen promise in pre-production.** Shooting on IMAX film (The Odyssey) or two 65mm formats (Sinners) gave each campaign a reason to see the film in a theater, and premium screens returned 45–53% of their openings.
2. **Start seven months out, or more.** First trailers landed 206–380 days before release; The Odyssey put tickets on sale a full year early and they sold out almost at once.
3. **Budget marketing at half to one times production.** Reported spend ran $55M–$150M (50–103% of budget) and returned $2.55–$4.91 per dollar of total cost. Spending more did not buy a better return.
4. **Make the release an event.** Year-early presales, Barbenheimer double features and 100+ brand partners made going feel like a must.
5. **Build in something fans share.** Small fan accounts drove a third of The Odyssey's TikTok views, and 13M people made Barbie posters. Seed everyday fans, not only big accounts.
6. **Protect the second weekend.** All three earned an A CinemaScore and ran 3.9–5.8 times their opening; Sinners fell only 5% in weekend two on word of mouth.

The small-budget playbook ($750K–$25M)

On a small budget the audience is the marketing department, so build campaigns fans want to share.

1. **Start with a built-in community.** Two of the three came from YouTube creators: Curry Barker's channel (1.62M subscribers) and Kane Parsons' Backrooms series (about 200M views before release).
2. **Spend where the camera sees it.** Obsession cost $750K and Backrooms put its $10M into real sets; they earned 695 and 40 times their budgets.
3. **Sell the film before spending on marketing.** Focus bought Obsession at a festival for about $15M, 20 times its budget, before a ticket was sold.
4. **Design participation, not impressions.** A text line with Nikki (400,000 sign-ups), a sold-out product drop, in-universe ads and the "Unwritten" exit dance (602M views) gave fans something to do.
5. **Spot fan trends early and join in.** Sony did not start the exit dance, but it amplified the trend and brought in the cast and the singer.
6. **Judge the run, not the opening.** Obsession and Anyone But You opened small and ran about 15 times their openings; Backrooms opened huge on its fandom and ran 2.4 times. A shorter runway can work: presales opened just 16–59 days out.

7. **Treat streaming as a second box office.** Anyone But You's thin theatrical margin became about $103M of profit (Deadline) through home viewing and its Netflix deal.

Five rules for any budget

The same pattern held at both scales: a trusted name, one clear promise, and something for the audience to do.

1. **Lock the hook in pre-production.** Format, casting and creator control were all decided before marketing began; marketing amplified those choices and did not create them.
2. **Lead with a name people trust.** A director (Nolan, 51%), a star (Jordan, 47%) or a community (the Backrooms story, 58%) was the top reason to buy a ticket.
3. **Make one clear promise.** Either an event to see in theaters or a question worth arguing about, such as whether Obsession's Bear is the villain.
4. **Hand fans something to do.** Fan-made content reached young audiences that paid ads missed, at every budget.
5. **Plan for the full run.** Word-of-mouth films earned about 15 times their opening; fan-driven Backrooms earned 2.4 times. Post-opening content matters as much as the launch.

Limitations and data gaps

Six films show patterns, not proof of cause, and each film's result also reflects its director, timing and quality.

- **Marketing spend is thin.** Studios never reported it for Obsession, and The Odyssey's $125M and Backrooms' $10M are unattributed media figures. No film has a public breakdown by channel.
- **Social samples are small.** Our own scrape covers The Odyssey in depth (2,406 posts); the other five rely on samples of 100 TikToks, top Reddit posts and press coverage. The 2023 X archive is too thin to compare Barbie and Anyone But You.
- **Some figures are company-reported.** Barbie's 4.6B hashtag views come from Mattel; Anyone But You's 2.7B and 602M views come from Sony's own case study.
- **Exit-poll questions differ.** Reasons to attend were only published for The Odyssey, Sinners and Backrooms, and age brackets vary by tracker.

- **The newest films are still moving.** The Odyssey is about four months old and its totals and scores may change.

Where the workbooks disagree, this paper follows the Six-Film Master Data. The open conflicts:

Figure	Value used	Other values in the workbooks
The Odyssey worldwide	$1.82B (Oct 29, 2026)	$1.80B (Gen Z Master, Nov 7); $1.795B (Technical Craft)
Obsession worldwide	$521.3M (Aug 13, 2026)	$523.6M (Technical Craft, Oct 28); $501.6M (Gen Z Master)
Obsession young audience	78% under 35 (PostTrak via NYT)	75% aged 18–25 (Gen Z Master)
Obsession budget	$750K	$700K to $1M across sources
Sinners craft Oscar nominations	9 (Technical Craft Master)	8 (Craft Data)
"Unwritten" TikTok views	602M (Sony case study)	290M (Cast Data, earlier snapshot)

Data sources

Every figure in this paper comes from the team's seven research workbooks. The original source for each value (box office trackers, trade press, review sites, exit polls and social tools) is logged in the Six-Film Master Data's Source Log and each workbook's Sources tab.

- Six-Film Master Data (box office, budgets, campaign, reception)
- Playbook Gen Z Six-Film Master Data (audiences, exit polls, Xpoz social samples)
- Cast Data (cast and fan metrics; 2,406 Odyssey posts)
- Technical Craft Data, Technical Craft Master Data and Technical Craft Raw Data (formats, production, profit model, coded posts)
- Odyssey Sentiment and Trust Analysis (Letterboxd, Reddit and Metacritic sentiment)
- Barbie's Rotten Tomatoes review count: Rotten Tomatoes, checked Nov 11, 2026

Companion website: The Pre-Production Marketing Playbook